

Lob Defense — Brief

1. Lesson Recap

Lob defense is how you recover when an opponent floats the ball high over your head toward the baseline to push you off the kitchen line. Most of the time your job is to survive the lob, neutralize it, and get your team back to the line — not to win the point outright. Stay safe: never backpedal flat-footed with your eyes up.

2. Big Idea

When you get lobbed, turn and go get it — don't backpedal. Rotating and running keeps you fast, balanced, and able to hit a usable shot.

3. Key Cues

- "Turn, don't backpedal."
- "Take it in the air if you can."
- "If it's deep, run past it and hit moving forward."

4. Step-by-Step

1. The instant the ball goes up, turn your hips and shoulders and drop-step toward where it's heading.
2. If you can reach it, set up underneath and hit an overhead at a high, comfortable contact point.
3. If it's deep, run past the bounce and push a soft reset into the kitchen, then recover to the line.

5. Common Mistakes

- Backpedaling on your heels: slow and unsafe. Turn and run or shuffle instead.
- Reaching back over your head: produces weak shots. Run past the ball and hit moving forward.
- Forcing a winner while scrambling: a calm reset keeps you in the point.

6. Self-Check

- Did I turn and run instead of backpedaling?
- Could I have taken that one out of the air with an overhead?
- Did I reset safely and get back to the line with my partner?

7. Homework

- Drop-step turn drill: partner points left or right; drop-step and turn that way. 15 each side.
- Overhead feed drill: hit 20 controlled overheads off easy lobs, favoring placement over power.
- Chase-and-reset drill: turn, run past a deep lob, and push a soft drop into the kitchen. 10 reps.

8. Game Application

Let the situation pick the shot: set under it for an overhead when you can, but when it's deep and over your head, switch from "attack" to "survive and reset." In doubles, the best angle takes the ball, the partner covers, and you call "Switch!" when you cross — neutralizing the lob and getting back to the line is a win in itself.

9. Quick Reminders

- Turn and run — never backpedal flat-footed.
- Take it in the air whenever you can.
- Talk: "Mine!" and "Switch!" then reset to the line together.